



Experience for yourself

Our short video comparison will give you an idea of subtle differences between the audio quality of the JBL speakers and how they compare with the Bose SoundLink Mini: <http://dgit.in/JBLBosecomp>

Portable Bluetooth Speakers



Zoook Air Drum ZB-BS100

rubberised body helped give it a rugged feel, the sound performance was abysmal. It was loud enough but badly distorted. The other model from the same line, the **MTV Soundbox** had a similar story. It was decent to look at but underperformed in terms of sound quality, however unlike the **Twister**, this one didn't even evoke confidence with its build. While on the topic of underperforming speakers, we were quite surprised and rather bummed about the prospect of clubbing the elegantly designed **F&D Swan** in this category. Now let's get to the speakers that actually stood out. The **Zoook Air Drum ZB-BS100** and the **iBall UFO3** were neck and neck in terms of performance and features. Both had all the bells and whistles in terms of various controls, sources they could take input from and looks. The Zoook had a nice bright sound signature and room filling sound. It was loud and although it looks like it's one of those mono speakers, it's actually stereo. One flaw is that its performance is on the lower end of the spectrum. On our *Dream Theater* test track the difference between this and the more expensive **Jam Plus** was noticeable – both seem to have the same level of detail

but the bass tuning of the **Jam Plus** gives it a more balanced or rather well rounded sound. The Zoook is loud and ready to make noise but the **Jam Plus** at least gave the illusion of some bass. The **Jam Classic** is literally like a stripped down version of the **Plus** – same design but relatively diminutive volume. The **Jam Classic** had a curious problem: it kept losing battery rapidly when left on –

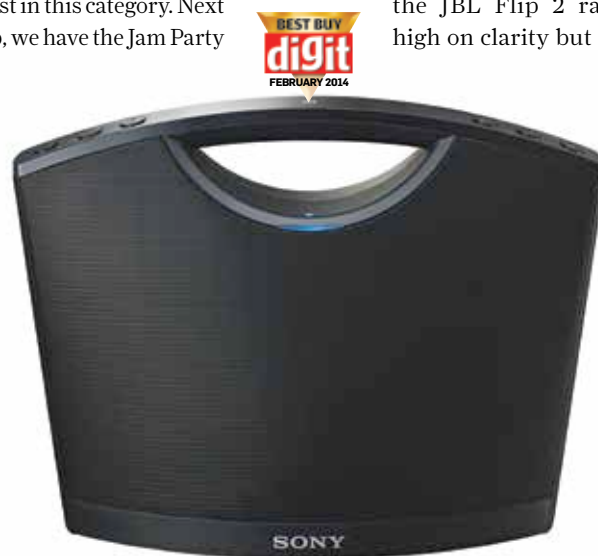
not desirable at all. The most standout feature within this category (and perhaps even in the whole test) was the ability of the **Jam Plus** to pair with another **Jam Plus** speaker to make it into a proper stereo set. The **Jam Plus** has a switch that lets you designate each mono speaker as either left or right channel. The effect (and loudness) that you get when running a pair of **Jam Plus** speakers in stereo is quite amazing. Hold each one a meter or so away from your ears and you get enveloped in an orb of sound. In terms of performance, the **Jam Plus** was the front-runner in this category but it's expensive too. As for the others, there isn't a lot of difference between Zoook, **UFO3**, **Jam Classic** or **Drums** in terms of pure sound quality. It just boils down to which is louder and what feature set you prefer. The Zoook however stands out as the best value for money proposition in terms of performance per unit of price. It gets our **Best Buy Award** in this category.

₹5,000 – UNDER ₹9,000

This is what we'd like to call the mid-range space for Bluetooth speakers. It has some of the most recognised names

in the industry; namely JBL, Sony, Edifier, UE, etc. Let's start with the Edifiers. The **Edifier Extreme Connect** was a strange little speaker; it seemed well built, was compact and in terms of design was a cross between the **Jambox** by Jawbone and the **Jabra Solemate** (which we've reviewed before, but isn't part of this test). It had a couple of things going for it like the availability of not just play/pause but also the forward/rewind controls on the device which were displayed in a funky random manner as if strewn about by accident. The performance, however, was not upto the mark. The sound was almost muffled and bass performance was bad. It produced no sound for the first three or four seconds of '*Angel*' by *Massive Attack*, except a slight buzzing. Most likely those few seconds, the bass notes are out of the device's frequency range. The **Edifier Bric Connect** is big, loud and runs on double AA batteries (which it eats through, in case you were wondering). It's incidentally the only one in the test with a remote, so that's a nice little addition. The sound quality is way better than the **Extreme Connect** but it's not the best in this category. Next up, we have the **Jam Party**

from HMDX. The speaker delivered very little thump in *Santana's 'While My Guitar'*, but produced soaring clarity. Nice open vocals, and the acoustic guitar sounded especially realistic. The trouble with the **Jam Party** is that its cut off doesn't seem to have been put in place properly. You can drive its transducers to the extremes resulting in distortion if you take it beyond 80 percent. That's pretty much its operational limit. This is something that the **UE Mobile Boombox** has managed very well. No matter how much you push it, the speaker just won't distort. The mid range clarity and quantity of bass on the **UE Mobile Boombox** is pretty good – there's almost no clipping in any song. The price of a tiny footprint though is that there's not enough volume output. It's great for a close quarters experience but you won't get that room filling sound. The only JBL to feature in this category is the **JBL Flip 2** – an impressive upgrade to our old favourite **JBL Flip**. Amongst other things not present in the original **Flip**, such as Micro-USB charging, is NFC pairing present in **Flip 2**. In terms of performance, the **JBL Flip 2** ranks high on clarity but even-



Sony SRS-BTM8